

TASTE

The tongue's taste buds contain taste receptors that feed messages to the brain. When we sip tea, saliva is secreted and flavors are changed and moderated. To taste and evaluate the character of a tea, slurp rapidly to spread the tea over all the receptors on the tongue.

ASTRINGENCY

Taste and texture come together to create astringency, an important characteristic of tea. It is the puckering or drying sensation in the mouth caused by the chemical reaction of the tea with saliva. Astringency occurs in varying degrees, depending on the amount of polyphenols (tannins) released during the tea's infusion. Tea connoisseurs value astringency in the right amount, but too much is unpleasant.

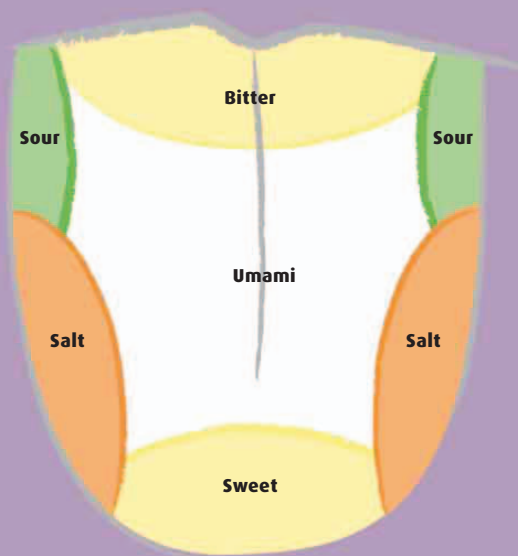
TEXTURE

You will feel the texture of tea when it comes into contact with the teeth and the mucous membranes lining the inside of the mouth. This is often referred to as "mouthfeel." The astringency, body, and smoothness of the tea determine the texture. Teas with low astringency might have a "soft mouthfeel," while teas with a high degree of astringency might have a "fuzzy mouthfeel."

THE TONGUE

Covered with 10,000 taste buds, each containing 50–100 taste receptor cells, the tongue is capable of identifying five basic tastes: sweet, salty, sour, bitter, and umami (a Japanese term meaning "pleasant savory taste"), each in a specific area.

The diagram below illustrates what is commonly known as the "tongue map." It shows each distinct area of the tongue with the receptors for sweet on the tip, receptors for salt on either side of the front of the tongue, sour receptors on either side behind this, and bitter receptors at the back. Umami is detected in the center of the tongue, which scientists had previously thought to be taste blind. When tasting tea, it's important to make sure the liquor reaches each of the five taste areas of the tongue so you are able to experience all of the flavors.



**QUICKLY SLURP THE
TEA TO STRIKE ALL
OF THE TASTE
RECEPTORS ON
THE TONGUE**